START™ SPECIAL REPORT · THE VIABILITY TRIANGLE

An Idea Is Worth Nothing

A founder's guide to turning a venture into something worth backing — before you burn the runway finding out.

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The pitch lands. The room leans in. Someone says “this is really interesting” — and means it. Then the follow-up never comes. Not a no. Just quiet.

Every founder has lived that silence. And almost every founder reads it wrong — replaying the deck for weeks, convinced the story did not land. It landed perfectly. The story was never the problem. The vision excited them. The numbers behind it did not exist yet. And “interesting” is the word people use in the gap between the two.

> *The room stays excited. The runway does not.*

Here is the part nobody says out loud: the idea you are guarding so carefully — the one you make people sign an NDA before you’ll explain — is the part nobody is trying to steal. The same idea is sitting in a dozen other heads in a dozen other cities right now. What is rare, what capital actually pays for, is the part most founders treat as an afterthought.

Why Exciting Ideas Don’t Get Funded

Most founders believe the same thing: a strong enough idea will attract the capital to build it. Get the vision right, make people feel it, and the money follows. It does not. Vision opens the meeting. It does not close the round.

> *Investors do not back ideas. They back models that make the idea inevitable.*

Startup post-mortem data repeatedly shows the same pattern: ventures fail because the market does not pay, the cash does not last, or the unit economics do not hold. Almost none fail because the idea was bad. That is the Viability Triangle — autopsy data turned into a founder’s filter.

The Viability Triangle

The Viability Triangle is the architecture that turns an idea into an investable business. Three tests decide it — the same three that quietly kill the ventures that fail. Pass all three and you have a model. Fail one and you have a story.

MARKET — A MARKET THAT PAYS

Not a market that admires. A market that pays. A hundred people saying “I’d use that” is enthusiasm; one signed letter of intent, one offtake agreement, one customer who pre-pays is demand.

MONEY — MONEY THAT LASTS

Ventures die one milestone short of the proof that would have raised the next round. The test is whether the runway reaches the milestone that unlocks capital — not a vague horizon.

MARGIN — A MARGIN THAT HOLDS

A margin that only works in the spreadsheet is one you will defend in front of an investor who has seen a thousand of them. The test is whether the unit economics survive real costs — the bad day, not the best case.

STRUCTURE — THE FRAME

Market, money and margin only become backable when written into a structure someone outside your head can recognise: governance, a defensible commercial case, decisions an outsider can follow.

Proof — Bleriot, Sustainable Aviation Fuel, Kenya

Sustainable aviation fuel in East Africa was an obvious idea long before it was a company. Abundant feedstock. Demand written into law through CORSIA, ISCC and EU RED II. None of that was scarce. What turned it into something backable was the model: an offtake position built against mandated airline demand, a modular micro-refinery design that staged the capital so each increment bought a milestone, and unit economics anchored in real vegetable-oil feedstock rather than a single fragile mega-asset. The opportunity was always free. The model was the work.

> *The idea makes the meeting interesting. The model makes the wire transfer happen.*

Five Moves to Make It Investable

MOVE 1 — PROVE THE MARKET WILL PAY, NOT THAT IT APPROVES

Stop treating secrecy as strategy. Spend the energy on securing one piece of contracted demand — a letter of intent, a deposit, a pre-paid pilot.

MOVE 2 — MAP THE RUNWAY TO THE MILESTONE, NOT THE CALENDAR

Identify the single proof point that unlocks the next tranche of capital, and check the money reaches it with room to spare.

MOVE 3 — BUILD THE MARGIN ON REAL COSTS

Construct the unit economics from what things cost when they go wrong, then stress them. A margin that only holds on the best-case line is a wish, not a model.

MOVE 4 — WRITE THE MODEL INTO A STRUCTURE

Move it out of your head and into governance, a clear commercial case, and decisions an outsider can follow.

MOVE 5 — NAME WHAT YOU'VE ASSUMED VERSUS WHAT YOU'VE TESTED

An assumption written down is a managed risk. An assumption left unspoken is a future failure with a date on it you have not seen yet.

The Objections You're Probably Raising

"The idea is the hard part — the model comes later."

The idea is the easy part; ideas are abundant and free, which is exactly why they get no premium. The model is the scarce thing, and therefore the thing that gets funded.

"We'll figure out the numbers once we have customers."

By then the numbers are no longer a question you answer — they are a verdict you receive. Working out the unit economics before you scale is cheap. Discovering them after is the most expensive lesson in the venture's life.

"Investors back vision, not spreadsheets."

They back vision underwritten by a model. Vision is the reason they take the meeting; the model is the reason they wire the money.

"If I share the idea, someone will steal it."

If the idea is that easy to steal, it was never the moat. What is hard to copy is a proven market, a funded path and a margin that holds — and you cannot build any of those in secret.

The Core Truth

> *The idea is the cheapest thing you own. The model is the only thing worth protecting.*

Across 30 countries, and ventures and programmes up to €2B, the ones that got backed were almost never the most exciting in the room. They were the most structured. The market was proven, the money was mapped, the margin was real — so when the scrutiny came, there was a business to defend rather than a story to oversell.

The Investability Ladder

Level 1 — Pitch-Deck Hope. An idea and a deck. No evidence anyone will pay.

Level 2 — Build Without Buyers. Product underway before any contracted demand exists.

Level 3 — Numbers in the Head. Market, money and margin live in the founder's head — untested.

Level 4 — Tested Model. Demand evidenced, runway mapped to a milestone, unit economics stressed.

Level 5 — Investable Platform. All three tests passed and written into a governed structure.

> *An idea is worth nothing. A model is worth backing.*

Do you have an idea — or a model?

Take the START diagnostic. Twenty questions. Four minutes. It shows whether your venture has a market that pays, money that lasts, and a margin that holds.

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